“What are we going to do?” Léa whispered, her voice shaking.

“It will be all right. Don’t trust the man he sends here.” A fierce light shone in Édouard’s eyes. “You told me once to ask if I needed help—do you remember?”

She nodded.

“I’m asking now. Can you be a friend to Virginie and Paulette, protect them in case I don’t come back?”

“You will return!” She gripped his hand. “Tell me you will.”

He leaned in. “Finish the work I still have to do.” Léa stiffened, remembering the demijohns in the hidden hatch. “Can I rely on you?”

“Yes,” she whispered, heart pounding, unsure what she’d just agreed to.

* * *

The house that afternoon felt empty. Usually, Virginie went to fetch Paulette at school, but she’d sent Rose so that she and Léa could talk in private. They sat at the round table in the dining room as she told Virginie what had happened. Virginie didn’t seem shocked, but concern filled her eyes. Léa felt a cold chill and cupped her hands around the mug of tea Virginie had placed on the table.

“We have a problem,” Virginie said a little later.

“With the wine?”

“It’s already been sold and the delivery confirmed for the day after Weinführer Brucker collects the ethanol.”

“Maybe Édouard will be back by then?”

Virginie tented her fingers, elbows on the table. “We can’t rely on that. We must be ready to deliver it without Édouard.”

Léa remembered how heavy the four-liter demijohns were to lift into the crates. Could they move that many jugs without being seen?

Virginie’s index finger slid like a silent blade along her neck. “The smugglers are gangsters. They won’t hesitate to denounce Édouard to the Weinführer if we don’t deliver.”

“But isn’t the smuggler also guilty?”

“He can lie, say that Édouard proposed meeting him, but he came to tell the Weinführer. He’ll likely collect a reward, and he might even be given some of the cases.”